Henry's dilemma gave the barons of England the chance to air thirty years' worth of complaints and grievances. Certainly Henry could have his money, the barons told their king, as soon as he fulfilled their conditions: he was to expel most of his French-born officials from England; he was to reaffirm all of the provisions of the Magna Charta; and he was to hand final decisions of policy over to a chamber of twenty-four leading barons, twelve chosen by him, twelve by the Curia Regis. "They moreover insisted that the king should frequently consult them, and listen to their advice," Paris concludes.[8]

Unlike his father John, Henry was unwilling to risk excommunication. On June 11, 1258, he agreed to sign the barons' demands, set down in a written treaty known as the Provisions of Oxford. The original demands had morphed: he was now to accept a standing council of fifteen who would have to ratify all his decisions, as well as another committee of twelve *and* the original council of twenty-four.[9]

But the army to conquer Sicily, and the pope's fee, did not materialize. A dry season in England led to a drastic shortage of food, which led to famine and disease: "A measure of wheat rose in price to fifteen shillings and more," Paris writes, "at a time when the country itself was drained of money, and numberless dead bodies were lying about the streets." Alexander IV extended the deadline for payment. Meanwhile, the English barons expanded the Provisions of Oxford into the more elaborate Provisions of Westminster, placing even more limitations on Henry's ability to raise money.[10]

Henry III had given up a whole raft of royal privileges and gotten nothing in return. But he had King John's example to lead him; he opened secret negotiations with Alexander IV, pointing out that he could raise the money he owed if he were freed, by papal decree, from the Provisions of Oxford.

Alexander seems to have agreed. On April 13, 1261, he issued a papal bull freeing the king from all obligation to both Provisions; and on June 14, Henry sent the bull to be read out loud to the newly formed councils, which had assembled at Winchester.[11]

The barons, led by Simon de Montfort, began to prepare for war.

Fighting did not begin immediately. Neither the barons nor Henry were ready to launch a full-scale civil war; and the famine of 1258 had been followed by several good years of crops and rising prosperity, which meant that the English as a whole were not inclined to revolt. Instead, nearly three years of increasingly ill-tempered negotiations commenced. Alexander IV died, shortly after issuing the bull, but his successor Urban IV confirmed it; Simon de Montfort remained Henry's most inflexible foe, but other barons